A Survey on Educational Needs of Social Workers in Health: Implications for Hospice and Palliative Social Work

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ABSTRACT

A survey was designed to assess the educational needs & preferences of health social workers: educators, practitioners & students. Designed to further understanding of the academic and continuing education needs of social workers who are focused on meeting the expanding need for generalist and specialist level Social Work clinicians providing services in health care settings, the survey is anticipated to inform our understanding of respondents' perspectives & wisdom related to learning, teaching and practice.

•The goal of this survey is to develop ideas about educational tools to enrich curriculum, enhance preparation & practice of health social workers.

•Investigators made efforts to disseminate the survey widely in social work education and practice circles.

•Participants were asked to rate various skills as to their importance, & share how they gained competency in these areas.

•The survey included basic & anonymous information such as practice setting, level of education & years of practice.

•Preliminary findings from 1390 respondents, implications for the professional training, as well as continuing education and preparations for the specialty practice area of hospice & palliative care are discussed.

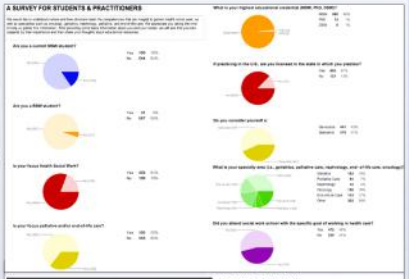
•The investigators, represent educators, practitioners & current students discuss areas for future study with the aim of preparing social workers for the anticipated growing demands of health care social work practice.

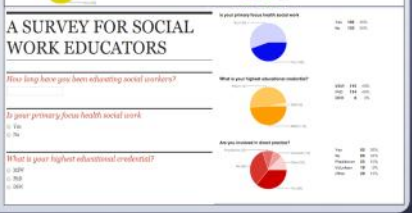
DESIGN AND METHODOLOGY

- Qualitative survey designed to assess the educational needs & preferences of health care social workers including educators, practitioners & students. Questions addressed education level, professional training & perspectives about preparedness, professional focus and scope of practice & asked respondents to provide narrative feedback about gaps & opportunities in training.
- Survey questions were informed by existing literature & practical experience of clinicians involved in research.
- Institutional Review Board approval was obtained through Beth Israel Medical Center
- Invitations were sent by email for an Internet survey using *Google Forms* to nine professional social work organizations (CSWE, SSWR, DU, NADD, AOSW, APOSW, NASW, SWHPN, NCHPN, NHPCO) with a request that these organizations disseminate the survey to their networks yielding a purposive, snowball sample.
- The Research Team provided follow-up with organizational contacts via email & phone conference to answer questions and concerns, ensuring cross organizational understanding of research intent & appropriate audience.
- Response data have been collected & are being analyzed using Google analytics, thematic content analysis & ATLAS.ti data analysis software

RESPONDENTS

- 1149 students & practitioners participated in the survey.
- 241 self-identified social work educators. On average, they had been teaching for 16 years, ranging 1 - 48 years of experience.
- Overlap noted in who identified as a student and as clinician
- 644 self-identified students
- 977 self-identified clinicians
- Clinicians have been practicing for an average of 19 years.





IMPLICATIONS FOR FURTHER RESEARCH

•Respondents indicate a need for health social work courses in standardized MSW education.

•Subjects that respondents would like covered in more detail include but are not limited to family systems work, aging, addiction and substance abuse, alternative & complementary therapies, specific interventions & clinical skills including CBT for the medically ill, elaboration on issues specific to the role of health social workers including interdisciplinary team dynamics, documentation, navigating the health care system, social justice framework including cultural, racial & LGBT issues in health, professional development for SW in health care including leadership & administration roles, and building understanding of specific medication conditions, terminology and pharmacology.

• Barriers to continuing education are money, time and location. Fewer organizations are able to support continuing education and professional development financially. Respondents reported that pursing CEU's online has limitations both in access to expert and specialist level content and the number of CEU credits individual states count towards licensure.

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